

Administrative Writing — Intermediate: Answer Key

For instructor use only. Not for distribution to students.

Model answers are provided for all exercises with specific expected responses. Guidance notes are given for open-ended exercises (Freer Practice, Transfer Extension, Reflection, Homework). Where model answers are already printed in the student book (e.g., after a revision lab), they are referenced rather than repeated.

MODULE 1. Foundations of Clear Administrative Writing

1

Clear Sentence Structure

A. WARM-UP — SENTENCE COMPARISON

Answers: 1b, 2b, 3b

- 1b: Brings subject to front; removes embedded clause
- 2b: Uses a direct polite imperative; removes the formal passive opening
- 3b: Reduces relative clause to participial phrase; shorter and cleaner

C. LANGUAGE 1 — PRACTICE: IDENTIFY THE PARTS

#	Subject	Verb	Object / Complement
1	Our office	received	your email (<i>yesterday = adverb</i>)
2	The applicant	submitted	the additional documents
3	We	will check	the application (<i>today = adverb</i>)
4	The system	shows	an error message
5	The examiner	requested	more information

C. LANGUAGE 1 — PRACTICE: BUILD CLEAR SENTENCES

1. Our office received your application yesterday.
2. The examiner requested more information.
3. We will send a confirmation email tomorrow.
4. The applicant has not submitted the fee yet.
5. The system showed an error message this morning.

C. LANGUAGE 2 — SIMPLIFY THE SENTENCE

1. We are checking the details from your email. / We received your email yesterday and are now checking the details.
2. Our department has decided to extend the document submission deadline to 30 June.

3. The system is under maintenance, so we cannot access your file at the moment.
 4. If the applicant does not provide the required documents, we cannot continue the examination.
-

D. GUIDED PRACTICE — REWRITE FOR CLARITY

1. We are checking your application and need more time. / We are currently checking your application and require a little more time.
 2. The document attached to your Monday email is different from the one we discussed.
 3. Our guidelines require us to contact the applicant if documents are missing.
 4. We need to confirm the information with another department before we can reply.
-

G. EDITING PRACTICE — FIX THE READER PROBLEM

1. We are now checking the file that the applicant sent after Monday's meeting. *(Removes embedded clauses; places action at front)*
 2. The supervisor explained that a new review step will be necessary for the application. *(Changes "It has been explained by" to active voice)*
 3. The check could not continue because some form items were incomplete and the database was unavailable. *(Removes doubled "because"; simplifies)*
 4. We are writing to ask you to send the correct version of the attached file. *(Removes "for the purpose of")*
-

MODULE 1 REVIEW — REVISION LAB

Model answer is printed in the student book (the ::example-good block after the exercise).

Key improvements:

- Split the single long run-on sentence into four shorter ones
 - Changed "please reply quickly" to "Could you please send the missing information by Thursday?"
 - Ended with a polite cooperative closing
-

2

Professional Tone Basics

A. WARM-UP — WHICH SOUNDS MORE PROFESSIONAL?

Answers: 1b, 2b, 3b

All b options use polite modal question forms (“Could you”, “Could you explain”) which reduce the imperative pressure of the a options.

C. LANGUAGE 1 — PRACTICE: MAKE THE REQUEST POLITE

1. Could you please send the updated form?
 2. Could you please let me know the deadline?
 3. Would it be possible for you to check the file?
 4. Could you please provide the information I need? / Could you please send me the information?
-

C. LANGUAGE 2 — CHANGE THE TONE

1. I notice the document has not yet been received. / It appears the document has not been sent yet.
 2. I am unable to complete this at the moment as the system is currently under maintenance.
 3. I believe there may be an error in the information provided. Could you please check?
 4. As mentioned in my previous message, ... / I would like to follow up on the information I shared yesterday.
-

D. GUIDED PRACTICE — REWRITE THE EMAIL

Original: “Hi, You didn’t send the right file. Send the correct one today. I need it now.”

Model rewrite: > Subject: Correct File Required — Application Review > > Dear [Name], > > Thank you for your message. I noticed that the file received does not appear to be the correct version for this review. Could you please send the correct file today? I appreciate your assistance. > > Thank you.

G. EDITING PRACTICE — REMOVE THE TONE PROBLEM

1. The incorrect file was received. Could you please send the correct version when you have an opportunity?
 2. Could you please let me know what happened?
 3. I have a question about the earlier check. Could you help me understand what occurred?
 4. Could you please send the update today at your earliest convenience?
-

3

Paragraph Structure

A. WARM-UP — WHICH IS A BETTER PARAGRAPH?

Answer: A

Paragraph A keeps all sentences on the same topic (reviewing the guidelines). Paragraph B mixes four unrelated topics and reads like disconnected notes.

C. PRACTICE A — IDENTIFY THE PARTS

Paragraph 1:

1. T — Topic sentence (states main action)
2. S — Supporting detail (the finding)
3. C — Closing sentence (connects to the process)

Paragraph 2:

1. T — Topic sentence
 2. S — Supporting detail
 3. C — Closing sentence
-

C. PRACTICE B — REORDER AND EXTEND

Best order: B → A → C

1. B: We checked the application yesterday. (*background*)
2. A: Two forms were missing from the submission. (*main finding*)
3. C: These issues form part of the initial documentation review. (*broader context*)

Add one supporting sentence (many correct answers):

- The missing forms affect the first documentation check and may delay the next review step. (*This example is suggested in the exercise itself.*)
 - Without these documents, we cannot proceed to the next stage of the review.
-

D. GUIDED PRACTICE — WRITE A BETTER PARAGRAPH

Original: “We checked the application yesterday. One document was missing. The missing document is required for further review. It is essential for completing the examination process. The applicant sent the wrong version before.”

Model rewrite (5–6 sentences, T→S→C):

We completed the initial review of the submitted application yesterday. During the review, we identified that one required document was missing from the file. This document is an essential part of the examination process and cannot be substituted. Without it, the review cannot proceed to the next stage. We also noted that the applicant had previously submitted an incorrect version of this form. This information will be recorded as part of the preliminary documentation check.

G. EDITING PRACTICE — REPAIR THE PARAGRAPH LOGIC

Original: “The file review started this morning. The office printer will be replaced next week. Two sections of the form were incomplete. These missing sections may delay the next stage.”

Problem: One off-topic sentence (printer); remaining sentences need reordering.

Model rewrite:

We started the file review this morning. During the review, we found that two sections of the form were incomplete. These missing sections may delay the next stage of the process. We will contact the applicant to request the missing information before the review can continue.

MODULE 2. Essential Email Writing for Administrative Contexts

4

Email Layout and Standard Phrases

A. WARM-UP — WHICH EMAIL IS BETTER?

Answer: B

Email B has: a specific subject line, a professional greeting, a clear purpose in the opening sentence, a specific question, and an appropriate closing. Email A leaves the reader guessing about the topic, document, and writer.

C. LANGUAGE 1 — PRACTICE: IMPROVE THE SUBJECT LINE

1. Question About Yesterday's Document → **Question About Document / Document Clarification Needed**
2. I want to ask about submitting the missing form → **Missing Form Submission — Query**
3. I am writing because there is a problem with the online system → **Online System Issue**
4. I need to know why the applicant has not received the confirmation → **Confirmation Notice Status**

Goal: Short (2–4 words), compound-noun style, no first-person “I am writing...”

C. LANGUAGE 2 — PRACTICE: CHOOSE AN OPENING AND CLOSING

1. **Colleague (internal document):**
 - Opening: Dear [Name], / Dear Team,
 - Closing: Thank you. / Kind regards,
 2. **Applicant:**
 - Opening: Dear Mr./Ms. [Name],
 - Closing: Thank you. / Please let me know if you need further information.
 3. **Foreign office:**
 - Opening: Dear [Office Name] Team,
 - Closing: Thank you for your assistance. / Kind regards,
-

C. LANGUAGE 3 — PRACTICE: WRITE THE OPENING SENTENCE

1. I am writing to ask about a missing document from the recent submission.
 2. I would like to confirm the deadline for the current application review.
 3. I would like to provide an update regarding the scheduled system maintenance.
-

D. GUIDED PRACTICE — BUILD A COMPLETE EMAIL

Situation: Confirm required documents for an application.

Model email:

Subject: Required Documents — Application Review

Dear Mr./Ms. [Name],

I am writing to confirm the documents required for the current application review. Could you please let me know whether Form A and the supporting identification documents are needed at this stage? This information will help us prepare the file before submission to the next department. Please let me know if you need any further information.

Thank you. [Name]

G. EDITING PRACTICE — REPAIR THE EMAIL STRUCTURE

Original: > Subject: Help > Hi, > I saw the file and I do not understand part of it and maybe there is also a problem with one page so please tell me what this means. > Thanks.

Model rewrite:

Subject: Question About Submitted File

Dear [Name],

I am writing to ask about the file received this morning. I have a question about one section: could you clarify what is required on page 3? There also appears to be some missing information in the document. Please let me know if I have misunderstood.

Thank you. [Name]

5

Requesting Clarification

A. WARM-UP — WHAT IS UNCLEAR?

1. “The document is not correct.” — *Which document? What exactly is incorrect?*
 2. “Please check it again.” — *Check what? Which specific part?*
 3. “We need information about the form.” — *Which form? What specific information?*
 4. “The deadline has changed.” — *What is the new deadline? Which process does it apply to?*
-

C. PRACTICE A — MAKE THESE QUESTIONS CLEARER

1. Could you clarify which section of the document needs to be corrected?
 2. I am not sure I understand Section 3 of the form. Could you explain what information should be included?
 3. Could you provide more details about which specific documents are required for this stage?
 4. Could you let me know what the next step is and whether I should take any action before then?
-

C. PRACTICE B — IMPROVE THE CLARITY

1. Could you clarify how the current requirement differs from the version you mentioned previously?
 2. Could you explain which specific step in the instructions is unclear? I would like to follow the correct procedure.
 3. I am not sure what information is required in this section. Could you clarify what I should include here?
 4. Could you describe the issue you are experiencing with the system so we can investigate further?
-

C. PRACTICE C — CLARIFICATION FROM CONTEXT

Scenario 1: “Submit the form as soon as possible.”

1. Could you clarify what the specific deadline is for submitting the form?

2. Could you confirm whether we should submit directly to your office or through the shared system?

Scenario 2: Two files named “Application_Final”

1. Could you confirm which version of the file is correct for this month's review?
2. Could you clarify the submission dates of the two versions so we can identify the most recent one?

Scenario 3: “Please prepare the report.” (no details given)

1. Could you let me know which data should be included in the report?
 2. Could you confirm the expected format and the submission deadline?
-

D. EXTENDED GUIDED PRACTICE — REWRITE AND IMPROVE

1. Could you clarify which part of this process is unclear? I want to follow the correct procedure.
 2. We have received two files that appear to be different versions. Could you confirm which one is correct for the current review?
 3. Could you explain what I should do with this form? I am not sure which section requires my input.
 4. Could you clarify what error was found in this part? I would like to correct it as soon as possible.
-

G. EDITING PRACTICE — FIX THE CLARIFICATION PROBLEM

1. Could you clarify which step in the instruction requires attention? I want to follow the correct process.
 2. We received two files with the same name. Could you confirm which version should be used for this review?
 3. The deadline in the notice differs from the one on the form. Could you confirm which date is correct?
 4. Could you let me know what format and content are expected in the report requested by the supervisor?
-

6

Communicating Delays or Changes

A. WARM-UP — WHAT INFORMATION IS MISSING?

1. "The review will be delayed." — *By how long? Why?*
 2. "The schedule has changed." — *What changed? What is the new schedule?*
 3. "We cannot finish this today." — *What task? When will it be complete?*
 4. "The system will be updated." — *When? Who is affected? For how long?*
-

C. PRACTICE A — IMPROVE THE CLARITY

1. The meeting has been delayed until Thursday because the updated file set is not yet complete.
 2. The submission procedure has been updated. From next week, all forms should be sent directly to the central review office.
 3. The report will be submitted on Monday instead of Friday because additional information is needed for one section.
 4. The system is running slowly due to a temporary server issue. Access will return to normal once the maintenance is complete.
-

C. PRACTICE B — REORDER TO MAKE A CLEAR UPDATE

Best order: B → C → A

1. B: The system will be under maintenance on Friday. (*what is happening*)
 2. C: Users may not be able to access certain functions. (*effect on users*)
 3. A: This may affect the planned timeline. (*broader impact*)
-

C. PRACTICE C — ADD SUPPORTING INFORMATION

1. The deadline for this review has been extended to 30 June. This change was made because additional documentation was required. The review will continue once all materials have been received.

2. The applicant's file will be reviewed next week instead of the original schedule. The required verification documents were only received today. An update will be provided once the review is complete.
 3. The submission procedure has been updated to include an additional identification check. This change applies to all new applications from this month. Further details will be shared in the updated guidelines.
-

D. GUIDED PRACTICE — WRITE AN UPDATE EMAIL

Situation: Review delayed for additional verification.

Model email:

Subject: Review Delay — Additional Verification Required

Dear [Name],

I am writing to inform you that the review planned for this week has been delayed. Additional verification is required for two of the submitted documents. This may affect the original schedule by one to two days. We will confirm a new timeline once the verification is complete.

Thank you for your patience. [Name]

G. EDITING PRACTICE — REMOVE THE READER'S UNCERTAINTY

1. The meeting has been rescheduled from Tuesday to Thursday at 2 p.m. This change was made because the updated document set will not be ready in time.
 2. We are unable to complete the file check today because the shared folder is temporarily inaccessible. We expect access to be restored tomorrow morning.
 3. A problem was found with two submitted documents. The relevant sections were incomplete, which means the review cannot continue at this stage.
 4. The system update will require approximately three hours. During this period, some review functions may be temporarily unavailable.
-

7

Making Requests Politely

A. WARM-UP — WHICH REQUEST SOUNDS MORE APPROPRIATE?

Answers: 1b, 2b, 3b

All b options use polite modal forms. They reduce the pressure of the a options while keeping the request clear.

C. PRACTICE A — REWRITE THE REQUEST

1. Could you please send the updated file by end of day? We need it for the next review stage.
 2. Could you let me know the deadline for this application? This will help us plan the next steps.
 3. Could you please check Section 2 of the form and confirm whether the information is complete?
 4. I would appreciate it if you could provide the applicant's current contact details. This information is needed for the next stage of the review.
-

C. PRACTICE B — MAKE THE REQUEST MORE SPECIFIC

1. Could you please send the completed version of Form B — the one dated 15 May?
 2. Could you check whether all required signatures are present on page 3 of the application?
 3. Could you confirm whether the applicant's submission date has been recorded correctly in the system?
 4. Could you update me on whether the missing documents have been uploaded to the shared folder?
-

C. PRACTICE C — SOFTEN THE REQUEST

1. Could you please send this by end of day when you have an opportunity?
2. Could you let me know the result when it is available?
3. Could you check this when you have a moment?
4. Could you send the corrected file at your earliest convenience?

D. GUIDED PRACTICE — WRITE A REQUEST EMAIL

Situation: Request the applicant's updated contact information.

Model email:

Subject: Updated Contact Information Required

Dear Mr./Ms. [Name],

I am writing to request your current contact details for our records. We need this information to proceed to the next stage of your review. Could you please provide your current email address and telephone number at your earliest convenience? This will help us confirm the next steps with you directly.

Thank you for your cooperation. [Name]

G. EDITING PRACTICE — KEEP THE REQUEST, IMPROVE THE TONE

1. Could you please send the corrected file today when you have an opportunity?
 2. Could you let me know the meeting time when it has been confirmed?
 3. Could you please review this and send your feedback at your earliest convenience?
 4. Could you please provide the missing information? This will help us continue the review.
-

MODULE 2 REVIEW — EMAIL COMPARISON (VERSION A VS. B)

Answer: B is more professional.

Discussion points:

1. B uses "Could you please" (polite modal); A uses an imperative ("Send")
 2. B gives a reason ("to complete the report before the afternoon deadline"); A gives no context
 3. B is appropriate for a colleague or external contact; A sounds demanding
-

MODULE 3. Administrative Procedures & Internal Communication

8

Writing Simple Procedures

A. WARM-UP — WHICH PROCEDURE IS BETTER?

Answer: B

Version B uses numbered steps with one clear action each. Version A mixes instructions, conditions, and explanatory notes in a single step, making the order hard to follow.

C. PRACTICE A — IMPROVE THE VERB CHOICE

1. Review the file and confirm all sections are complete.
 2. Enter the applicant's name in the system.
 3. Review the form to identify any missing sections.
 4. Submit the form to the designated department.
-

C. PRACTICE B — PUT THE STEPS IN ORDER

Best order: A → D → C → B

1. A: Review the file for missing documents. (*first check*)
 2. D: Confirm the submission date. (*verification*)
 3. C: Enter the applicant's information into the system. (*data entry*)
 4. B: Save the updated file. (*final step*)
-

C. PRACTICE C — ADD MISSING STEPS

Procedure 1:

1. Open the shared folder.
2. Download the file.
3. Review the file for completeness and accuracy.
4. Save the final version with the correct file name.

Procedure 2:

1. Review the applicant's form.

2. Check for required signatures.
 3. Confirm that all required documents are attached.
 4. Submit the completed form to the review department.
-

D. GUIDED PRACTICE — WRITE A SIMPLE PROCEDURE

Situation: Save a document in the correct team folder.

Model procedure:

1. Open the shared team folder on the network drive.
 2. Select the correct subfolder for the document type (e.g., Applications / Internal Reports).
 3. Rename the document using the standard naming format: [Date]/[Type]/[Reference].
 4. Save the document to the selected subfolder.
 5. Confirm the document appears correctly in the folder and is accessible to team members.
-

G. EDITING PRACTICE — REPAIR THE PROCEDURE

Original:

1. Check the file and maybe look at the applicant number too because this is important.
2. If everything is okay then save it, but first rename it if necessary.
3. Send it later.

Model rewrite:

1. Review the file for completeness and accuracy.
 2. Confirm the applicant ID number.
 3. Rename the file using the standard format.
 4. Save the renamed file to the correct shared folder.
 5. Submit the file to the next department.
-

9

Internal Notices

A. WARM-UP — WHICH NOTICE IS CLEARER?

Answer: B

Notice B has a clear heading, explains what happened, states current status, and gives a next step. Notice A is vague and leaves the reader without useful information.

C. PRACTICE A — IDENTIFY THE PARTS

1. E (Essential information — the review date)
 2. H (Heading)
 3. E (Essential information — note about older files)
 4. N (Next step)
-

C. LANGUAGE 2 — REWRITE TO MAKE THEM NEUTRAL

1. A delay has occurred in the review process. The team has been informed of the updated timeline.
 2. All staff are reminded to check the updated files before the end of the business day.
 3. The system is currently showing a temporary error. The issue is under investigation by the IT team.
 4. The meeting scheduled for this afternoon has been cancelled. A replacement date will be confirmed shortly.
-

D. GUIDED PRACTICE — WRITE A SHORT INTERNAL NOTICE

Situation: System maintenance this weekend.

Model notice:

Internal Notice — Scheduled System Maintenance

The file management system will undergo scheduled maintenance this weekend, from Saturday evening to Sunday morning. During this period, access to shared folders and the review database will be temporarily unavailable. Staff are advised to save all current work before Friday end of day. Normal system access will resume on Monday morning. Further information will be provided if the schedule changes.

G. EDITING PRACTICE — STRENGTHEN THE NOTICE

Original: > Notice > There is a problem with the files today. Please be careful. More later.

Model rewrite:

Internal Notice — Document Access Issue

A temporary issue has been identified with the file access system this morning. Some shared documents may be unavailable or difficult to open. The IT team is currently investigating the cause. An update will be provided once the issue is resolved. Staff are advised to save all work locally until normal access is restored.

10

Explaining Problems Clearly

A. WARM-UP — IDENTIFY THE MISSING INFORMATION

1. “The system isn’t working.” — *Which system? When? What is the effect?*
 2. “There is a problem with the file.” — *Which file? What kind of problem?*
 3. “The review is delayed.” — *By how long? Why? What is the new timeline?*
 4. “We cannot access the document.” — *Which document? Since when? Why?*
-

C. PRACTICE A — IMPROVE THE EXPLANATION

1. The uploaded file cannot be reviewed because two required sections are missing. The review will continue once the corrected version is received.
 2. The system is responding slowly due to a high volume of requests this morning. Access is expected to return to normal by early afternoon.
 3. We are unable to complete the verification check today because the required information has not yet been submitted. We will update you once all materials are received.
 4. The information in the document does not match the previous version on file. The discrepancy needs to be resolved before the review can continue.
-

C. PRACTICE B — ADD DETAILS

1. The application cannot be opened. / *The file appears to be in an unsupported format. / The IT team has been notified, and the applicant has been asked to resubmit.*
 2. The review is delayed. / *Two supporting documents are still missing from the applicant file. / The review can continue once the missing items are uploaded.*
 3. The uploaded form is incomplete. / *Sections 3 and 5 do not contain the required information. / The applicant has been notified and will need to resubmit a corrected version.*
-

D. GUIDED PRACTICE — WRITE A PROBLEM EXPLANATION

Situation: System error stopping reviewers from accessing files.

Model explanation:

We are reporting a system error that has affected file access since early this morning. Reviewers are currently unable to open files in the shared review folder. The error appears to be related to yesterday's server update. As a result, the review scheduled for today has been temporarily suspended. The IT team is currently working to resolve the issue, and we will provide an update as soon as normal access is restored.

G. EDITING PRACTICE — REPAIR THE PROBLEM LOGIC

Original: “There is a problem with the database. We cannot continue some work. Something is different in the uploaded files. Maybe more information will come later.”

Model rewrite:

A technical issue has been identified with the database this morning. As a result, the review process has been temporarily suspended. We also found that some uploaded files are displaying errors that prevent normal access. The IT team is currently investigating the problem and will provide an update shortly.

11

Writing Simple Meeting Summaries

A. WARM-UP — WHICH SUMMARY IS CLEARER?

Answer: B

Summary B names specific items (applicant list, updated guidelines), gives a clear decision (IT confirms on Monday), and provides the next meeting date.

C. PRACTICE A — IDENTIFY THE ELEMENTS

1. **T** (Topic — what the meeting was for)
 2. **D** (Decision — what the team agreed to)
 3. **M** (Main point — what was discussed and found)
 4. **A** (Action item — what will happen)
-

C. PRACTICE B — IMPROVE THE CLARITY

1. The team reviewed the document set during the review preparation meeting. The IT team will confirm system access before Monday.
 2. The meeting covered three areas: scheduling, document review, and IT access. The main decision was to extend the review period by two weeks. A follow-up meeting is planned to confirm next steps.
 3. The form was reviewed and found to contain incomplete information in two sections. The document coordinator will prepare a corrected version before Friday.
-

D. GUIDED PRACTICE — WRITE A SHORT MEETING SUMMARY

Situation: April schedule meeting; two tasks need more time; IT update needed first; next meeting Tuesday.

Model summary:

The team met today to review the April schedule. Two tasks require additional time and will not be completed within the original timeline. The IT team must complete a system update before the review can begin. A follow-up meeting has been scheduled for next Tuesday. Further updates will be provided once the IT update is confirmed.

G. EDITING PRACTICE — MAKE THE SUMMARY USABLE

Original: “We talked about the forms and some schedule issues. IT also said something about access. More discussion will happen later.”

Model rewrite:

The team met to discuss the review schedule and outstanding document issues. The main finding was that two forms still require additional confirmation. The IT team confirmed that system access for the review will be ready by Monday. A follow-up meeting is planned for later this week to finalise the preparation checklist.

MODULE 4. External Communication

12

Writing Simple External Inquiries

A. WARM-UP — WHICH INQUIRY IS BETTER?

Answer: B

Email B gives enough background context for the reader, asks one specific question, and uses a professional format with a clear subject line. Email A leaves the reader with no context and no clear question.

C. PRACTICE A — IMPROVE THE INQUIRY

1. We are reviewing the updated submission guidelines and have a question about the requirements. Could you clarify which specific part of the process applies to applications already submitted?
 2. We are preparing the updated submission file for next Friday. Could you confirm which version of the current rule applies to applications resubmitted this month?
 3. We are reviewing the documentation requirements for this quarter's applications. Could you confirm the final submission deadline?
 4. Our team is reviewing Section 2 of the current guidelines. Could you clarify how the updated rule applies to applications submitted before this month's change?
-

C. PRACTICE B — ADD BACKGROUND INFORMATION

1. We are reviewing the updated identification requirements for this year's application cycle. Could you clarify the new ID requirement?
 2. We are planning the next round of document checks and need to confirm the upcoming schedule. Could you confirm the review schedule?
 3. Our team has been informed of the updated rule, but it is unclear how it applies to our current case. Could you explain how the updated rule applies?
-

D. GUIDED PRACTICE — WRITE AN EXTERNAL INQUIRY EMAIL

Situation: Clarify new submission process from external office.

Model email:

Subject: Clarification Request — New Submission Process

Dear [External Office] Team,

Thank you for the updated instructions regarding the new submission process. We have reviewed the document and have one question about the submission order for applications received before this month.

Could you clarify whether applications submitted earlier this year should follow the previous process or the new process? This information will help us handle the current backlog correctly.

We appreciate your assistance and look forward to your response.

Kind regards, [Name]

13

Providing Simple Explanations

A. WARM-UP

Answer: B (clearer explanation) — provides background, states the finding, and includes a next step.

C. PRACTICE — IMPROVE THE EXPLANATION

1. We are reviewing the updated submission form. Could you clarify which section requires the applicant's official identification number? We want to ensure we complete the form correctly before the deadline.
 2. The applicant submitted the form with Section 3 incomplete. We need to confirm which information is required in that section before the review can continue. Could you advise?
-

G. EDITING PRACTICE

Model approach: Replace vague language with specific details; add the cause and effect of the issue; end with a neutral next-step line.

Instructor note: Award marks for: clear statement of the issue, specific cause or detail, effect on the current work, and a neutral closing line.

A. WARM-UP

Answer: B — The stronger response directly addresses the source of confusion, names the specific point, and maintains a professional cooperative tone.

C. PRACTICE — IMPROVE THE RESPONSE

1. Thank you for your message. I would like to clarify the point you raised about Section 2. The section refers to the most recently submitted form, not the original version.
 2. I understand the guidelines may be unclear on this point. Could you let me know which specific part is causing confusion? I will do my best to provide a more accurate explanation.
-

G. EDITING PRACTICE

Model approach: Address the specific source of confusion; keep tone neutral; provide the correct information; end with an offer of further help if needed.

15

Maintaining Consistent Email Style

A. WARM-UP — IDENTIFY THE INCONSISTENCIES

Email A problems:

- Subject line too vague (“Info”)
 - Greeting too informal and abbreviated (“Hi”)
 - Purpose completely unclear (“I saw it”)
 - No professional purpose sentence
 - Closing too casual (“Thx”)
-

C. PRACTICE A — IMPROVE CONSISTENCY

1. Dear [Name], I have reviewed the document and have a question about one section. Could you clarify what action is needed for this part? Thank you.
 2. Dear Team, I have been reviewing the attached file and noticed a possible issue. Could you clarify the situation so I can take the appropriate next step? Thank you.
 3. Dear Team, We have found that the attached file is not the correct version for this review. Could you please send the updated file? Thank you.
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MODULE 5. Advanced Editing & Revision Skills

A. WARM-UP

Instructor note: Exercise asks students to identify grammar problems. Common issues: subject-verb agreement, wrong article (a/the), tense inconsistency, wrong preposition.

Typical problem types in this unit:

- Incorrect verb agreement: “The files was received” → “The files were received”
 - Wrong article: “a information” → “the information” / “information”
 - Tense inconsistency: mixing past and present in one paragraph
 - Wrong preposition: “Check the system for errors on it” → “Check the system for errors in it”
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G. EDITING PRACTICE

Model approach: Correct all grammar errors; do not change meaning. Assess for: correct verb forms, article use, tense consistency, and preposition accuracy.

A. WARM-UP — WHAT MAKES THESE SENTENCES UNCLEAR?

1. "It looks like maybe there is something wrong with the form in some places." — *Vague hedges* ("looks like", "maybe"); *vague noun* ("something"); *vague location* ("in some places")
2. "We think the system might not be working correctly for some users." — *Hedges* ("think", "might"); *vague scope* ("some users")
3. "There are many things to check so it will maybe take a bit longer." — *Vague* ("many things", "a bit"); *unnecessary hedge* ("maybe")
4. "The information is kind of different from the last version." — *Informal hedge* ("kind of"); *vague* ("different" — *how different? which part?*)

C. PRACTICE A — MAKE THE SENTENCES CLEARER

1. The file has two incomplete sections.
2. Three items are missing from the form.
3. The review will be delayed by two days due to missing documentation.
4. Could you please check the document again?

C. PRACTICE B — REORGANISE FOR BETTER FLOW

Best order: B → A → C

1. B: We reviewed the applicant's file this morning. (*background*)
2. A: Two forms are incomplete. (*finding*)
3. C: This will delay the next review stage. (*result*)

D. GUIDED PRACTICE — EDIT FOR CLARITY

Original: "The system was slow today and we couldn't do much because of it. Also, there was a problem with the files and some people couldn't open them. So the schedule might change, and maybe we will need more time. There might be more information later."

Model rewrite:

The system was slow today due to a temporary server issue. As a result, some reviewers were unable to access the shared files. The review schedule will need to be adjusted because of this delay. An update will be provided once the system is fully operational.

A. WARM-UP

Instructor note: Exercise asks students to identify tone problems (too direct, too casual, emotionally charged). Key patterns to watch for: bare imperatives (“Send it now”), emotional language (“This is unacceptable”), and informal language (“Hey”, “ASAP”).

C. PRACTICE — IMPROVE THE TONE

Model approach: Replace direct imperatives with polite modals; remove emotional or pressuring language; add professional framing phrases.

Example transformations:

- “Send it now.” → “Could you please send it when you have an opportunity today?”
 - “This is unacceptable.” → “We would like to discuss how this issue can be resolved.”
 - “Why didn’t you do this?” → “I have a question about the earlier step. Could you clarify what happened?”
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MODULE 6. Integrated Tasks

Integrated Task 1: Combined Email + Internal Explanation

A. WARM-UP — UNDERSTANDING THE SITUATION

1. **The problem:** Form B - Declaration is missing a required signature.
2. **External office needs:** Confirmation that a corrected version will be submitted.
3. **Internal team needs:** An explanation of the issue, what action is required, and the timeline.
4. **Tone:** External = polite and professional; Internal = neutral and factual.

C. PRACTICE A — REWRITE FOR AUDIENCE & TONE

External Office — Make it polite: “Send us the correct form.” → > Could you please send us the correct version of the form at your earliest convenience?

Internal Team — Make it neutral and concise: “They said the applicant messed up the form again.” → > The external office has reported that the submitted form contains an error. The applicant will need to provide a corrected version.

External Office — Make it complete and professional: “What is the problem?” → > Could you clarify the specific issue identified with the submitted document? This will help us prepare the corrected version promptly.

Internal Team — Make it clear and factual: “The form is wrong but they didn’t explain well.” → > The external office identified an error in the submitted form but did not specify the exact nature of the issue. We are awaiting clarification before taking action.

D. GUIDED PRACTICE — WRITE THE EXTERNAL EMAIL

Model email:

Subject: Follow-Up — Form B Declaration (Application Ref: [Ref No.])

Dear [External Office] Team,

Thank you for your message regarding the submitted documents. We have reviewed your note and would like to follow up on the issue with Form B — Declaration.

Could you confirm whether the missing signature should be provided on the original form or whether a new completed form should be submitted? We want to ensure we send the correct version as promptly as possible.

We appreciate your assistance.

Kind regards, [Name]

D. GUIDED PRACTICE — WRITE THE INTERNAL EXPLANATION

Model explanation:

We received an update from the external office regarding the applicant's submitted documents. The main issue is that Form B — Declaration is missing a required signature. We now need to contact the applicant to request the corrected form and clarify the resubmission requirements with the external office. The next step will depend on their response, and we will update the team once further information is received.

Units 20–22. Integrated Tasks

These units use open-ended scenarios. Student responses will vary based on the scenario selected.

Instructor assessment guidance:

- Does the student adapt tone for different audiences (external vs. internal)?
 - Does the document follow the correct structure for its type (email, notice, explanation, summary)?
 - Is the language neutral, professional, and clear?
 - Does the student use relevant phrases from the unit's language section?
-

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Portfolio Writing & Final Revision

All exercises use the student's own previous writing as source material. No fixed model answers apply.

Instructor assessment guidance:

- Has the student improved accuracy (grammar, articles, tense)?
 - Is the revised version clearer and better organised than the original?
 - Does the tone match the stated audience (external, internal, colleague, supervisor)?
 - Are formatting and structure consistent across portfolio pieces?
 - Does the new Unit 23 document fit the standard set by the rest of the portfolio?
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APPENDIX. Grading Notes for Open-Ended Exercises

For all Freer Practice, Transfer Extension, Reflection, and Homework exercises:

Assess holistically. Does the writing show the target skill from the unit?

STRONG RESPONSE MARKERS BY DOCUMENT TYPE:

Type	Markers
Email	Clear subject line; polite greeting; purpose in first sentence; specific body; professional closing
Paragraph	Clear topic → supporting details → closing/next step
Procedure	Numbered; imperative verbs; logical order; one action per step
Clarification	Named unclear point; specific question; polite form
Problem explanation	Issue + cause + effect + current status
Meeting summary	Topic + decision + action item + next step
Notice	Heading + background + essential info + next step

tone markers:

Appropriate	Avoid
"Could you please..."	Bare imperatives ("Send it.")
"I am writing to..."	Vague openers ("Hi, About that thing...")
"We would like to inform you that..."	Emotional language
Neutral explanations	Blame language ("You didn't...", "Why did you...")

End of Intermediate Answer Key